MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 2 — Unit 1: Plays - Hamlet and Twelfth Night

SHAKESPEARE STUDIES • M21EG02DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Hamlet turns uncertain knowledge into tragic action, while Twelfth Night turns mistaken identity into a comedy with a troubling underside.

Start with a picture

In one theatre, a prince asks whether he can trust what he has been told. In another, a shipwrecked woman changes her outward identity to survive. Both stories make characters act on incomplete information, but their outcomes differ.

1. Hamlet: people and situation

Hamlet’s father is dead. His uncle Claudius has become king and married Gertrude, Hamlet’s mother. A Ghost claiming to be the dead king says Claudius murdered him and demands revenge. Horatio is Hamlet’s trusted friend; Polonius advises the court; Ophelia and her brother Laertes are Polonius’s children.

Follow the five-act movement

- **Act I:** the court’s public order contrasts with Hamlet’s grief; the Ghost introduces the accusation.
- **Act II:** surveillance increases. Hamlet adopts an unusual manner and encounters travelling players.
- **Act III:** the staged murder tests Claudius’s response. Hamlet confronts Gertrude and kills the concealed Polonius.
- **Act IV:** Hamlet is sent towards England; Ophelia’s distress deepens and she dies. Laertes returns seeking revenge.
- **Act V:** graveyard reflection leads towards the poisoned duel. Gertrude, Laertes, Claudius, and Hamlet die; Fortinbras arrives.

Exact divisions and readings vary between editions. Follow the course text when quoting.

Why the soliloquies matter

Early speeches express grief and disgust. The speech prompted by the players questions Hamlet's own inaction. "To be or not to be" considers existence, suffering, and the fear surrounding death. Later moments show changing attitudes to action and providence. Do not reduce every speech to the same complaint.

Madness and performance

Hamlet announces an intention to perform an "antic disposition," but that does not make every feeling false. Ophelia's distress is not simply the same performance in another character. Her songs expose grief and pressures the court has not adequately heard. Avoid using a modern diagnosis as a substitute for analysis.

Main questions

What counts as proof? Can revenge restore justice? How does spying damage trust? What happens when thought and violence fail to find a stable relation? The play within the play, the Ghost, and the final duel supply different forms of evidence and action.

2. Twelfth Night: people and situation

Viola survives a shipwreck and believes her twin Sebastian is lost. Disguised as Cesario, she enters Duke Orsino's service. Orsino loves Olivia, but Olivia falls for Cesario, while Viola loves Orsino. The audience can understand the triangle more fully than the characters.

Follow the main movement

The shipwreck establishes separation. Viola's disguise creates opportunity and emotional difficulty. Sir Toby, Maria, and their companions deceive Olivia's steward Malvolio with a forged letter. Sebastian arrives, creating mistaken encounters. Recognition distinguishes the twins and rearranges relationships, while Malvolio leaves angrily.

Why Malvolio matters

His ambition and self-importance make him vulnerable to the trick. Yet his confinement and treatment also reveal cruelty. The label "mad" can be used by other people to control someone; it should not be accepted as an objective medical judgement.

Other figures and unresolved edges

Feste's songs and wordplay test other people's claims. Antonio's loyalty to Sebastian introduces attachment and exclusion that marriage-based closure does not fully settle. Sir Andrew's aspirations and Sir Toby's behaviour complicate the festive atmosphere.

3. Compare the plays

Both use performance, misunderstanding, desire, and unequal knowledge. Hamlet intensifies uncertainty towards irreversible destruction. Twelfth Night turns the twin confusion towards recognition but does not remove every injury.

Quick check

1. Why stage a murder in Hamlet? **To test Claudius’s response to a representation of the alleged crime.**
2. Who knows Cesario is Viola? **The audience does, while several central characters do not.**
3. Is Malvolio’s final anger irrelevant to comedy? **No; it exposes the cost of the festive plot.**

Build an exam answer

1. Establish the shared problem of appearance and knowledge.
2. Analyse the Ghost, staged murder, and soliloquy.
3. Explain Viola’s disguise and the love triangle.
4. Use Malvolio to qualify the comic contrast.
5. Compare the endings and the cost of misinterpretation.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not call all of Hamlet’s emotion feigned, assume Ophelia’s precise state is clinically established, or describe Twelfth Night as happy for everyone.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Compare performance and uncertain knowledge in Hamlet and Twelfth Night.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

In both plays, performance changes what people can know and what they choose to believe. Hamlet encounters an accusation whose source may be uncertain, while Viola constructs an outward identity that others take for granted. Shakespeare uses these situations to make spectators aware of gaps between appearance, intention, and interpretation. The shared concern does not produce a shared emotional structure: one play moves towards tragic loss, the other towards a qualified comic recognition.

Hamlet’s staged murder is an attempt to convert theatrical representation into evidence. Claudius’s response becomes meaningful to Hamlet because it appears to confirm the Ghost’s account. Yet the wider play repeatedly shows the risks of reading signs. Surveillance, concealed listeners, and Ophelia’s use within courtly schemes make observation an instrument of manipulation as well as discovery. Soliloquies reveal an equally unstable inward process, in which reflection and self-judgement can lead towards different forms of action.

In Twelfth Night, the audience’s knowledge of Viola’s disguise generates dramatic irony. Olivia’s attraction is sincere even though its apparent object is misconceived. Viola’s position combines power, as an effective messenger, with vulnerability, as someone unable to declare her situation openly. The disguise therefore investigates gendered identity and desire rather

than merely producing accidental meetings.

The Malvolio plot complicates any easy contrast between a dark tragedy and a harmless comedy. A forged text directs his behaviour, and other characters use the resulting appearance to justify cruel treatment. In both plays, interpretive power has consequences. A strong comparison ends by asking whose knowledge wins authority and who suffers when performance is mistaken for truth.

How to use this discussion

Adapt the argument to the exact wording and marks of your question. Use one point per paragraph and support it with a scene, line, image, or formal detail. Verify exact quotations in the assigned text. The discussion is explanatory paraphrase, not a quotation or a guaranteed model answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit’s assignment prompts for revision. They are not predictions or a set of fully written assignment submissions.

1. Analyse Hamlet’s character development through his major soliloquies, examining how his understanding of his situation evolves throughout the play.
2. Compare the treatment of madness in both plays, contrasting Hamlet’s feigned madness with Ophelia’s genuine insanity and the comic madness attributed to Malvolio.
3. Examine the use of disguise and deception in Twelfth Night, discussing how these devices advance the plot and explore themes of identity and gender.
4. Evaluate the role of the supernatural in Hamlet, considering how the Ghost influences the action and reflects Elizabethan beliefs about the afterlife.
5. Discuss the concept of dramatic irony in both plays, providing specific examples of how Shakespeare uses audience knowledge to create tension or humour.